

6/10/26 IT Help Desk Lab Company-Wide Email Outage Using ServiceNow

Difficulty: High and Severe (Needs Extra Attention)

Background:

6/10/26 - 15:15

Within minutes, the help desk receives more than fifty calls.

Employees across Sales, Finance, Human Resources, Operations, and Executive Leadership report that they cannot send or receive email.

Several users report that their email application repeatedly asks for credentials.

Others report error messages indicating that the mail server cannot be reached.

The CEO's executive assistant calls directly and states that several critical client communications are delayed.

The company heavily relies on email for customer support, contract negotiations, vendor communications, and internal coordination.

When you check the monitoring dashboard, you notice alerts related to the email infrastructure.

At the same time, a network administrator sends a message in the IT team chat stating that they are investigating unusual authentication failures.

Social media monitoring shows that some customers are beginning to complain that nobody is responding to emails.

As a Tier 1 technician with a little over six months of experience, this situation can feel overwhelming.

Your responsibilities include:

- Creating accurate incident tickets.
- Identifying patterns from incoming calls.
- Gathering user reports.
- Communicating professionally with affected employees.
- Following incident management procedures.
- Escalating information to senior engineers.

Potential complications:

- A cloud service failure may cause the outage.
- DNS issues may be affecting authentication.
- A certificate may have expired.
- A cybersecurity incident may be occurring.
- Executives are demanding updates every fifteen minutes.

Business Impact:

Critical.

The outage affects nearly every employee and may impact customers, revenue, and company reputation.

Your challenge:

Remain calm, collect accurate information, avoid making assumptions, prevent duplicate tickets, communicate clearly, and support the incident response team while maintaining excellent customer service under pressure.

This is the type of situation where a future Help Desk Supervisor starts to separate themselves from an average technician. The goal is not to solve everything personally. The goal is to gather facts, communicate clearly, escalate correctly, and avoid making the situation worse. Include time stamps per comment to simulate a real environment.

Task/ Investigation duration: 20 - 30 minutes

 System Administrator

Comments • 2026-06-09 21:42:50

6/10/26 - 15:15

Incident Summary: The help desk received 50+ calls within minutes from multiple departments (Sales, Finance, HR, Ops, Executive) reporting a widespread email outage. Symptoms include repeated credential prompts and server connection errors, disrupting critical client communications and customer support.

Technical Findings: * Monitoring dashboard shows active alerts on the email infrastructure.

Network administration confirmed simultaneous investigations into unusual authentication failures.

External impact includes rising customer complaints on social media regarding unresponsive emails.



 System Administrator

Field changes • 2026-06-09 21:42:50

Impact

3 - Low

Incident state

New

Opened by

System Administrator

Priority

3 - Moderate

Screenshot 1: Major Incident Intake and Initial Enterprise Impact Assessment

The Help Desk identified a widespread email service disruption affecting multiple departments across the organization. Initial reports indicated failures in sending and receiving email, repeated

credential prompts, and email server connectivity errors. Infrastructure monitoring alerts, authentication-related concerns, and growing customer complaints confirmed the issue extended beyond individual users. Based on the number of affected employees, business-critical communication disruptions, and external customer impact, the event was classified as a Major Incident requiring immediate escalation and coordinated response.

 System Administrator Field changes • 2026-06-09 21:47:36

Incident state In Progress was New

 System Administrator Comments • 2026-06-09 21:47:35

6/10/26 - 15:18

Reviewed incoming incident volume and confirmed reports from Sales, Finance, Human Resources, Operations, and Executive Leadership.

Affected users report inability to send or receive email, repeated credential prompts, and mail server connection failures.

Monitoring systems continue to generate alerts associated with email services and authentication infrastructure.

Issue appears enterprise-wide and is not isolated to individual users, workstations, or departments.

Major Incident criteria confirmed. Messaging, Infrastructure, and Network teams notified for investigation.



Screenshot 2: Incident Scope Confirmed and Major Incident Declaration

Tier 1 analysis identified a widespread enterprise email outage affecting multiple departments, including Sales, Finance, Human Resources, Operations, and Executive Leadership. User reports revealed consistent symptoms such as credential prompts, mail server connection failures, and the inability to send or receive email. Correlation of user reports with monitoring alerts confirmed the issue was not isolated to individual workstations or departments. Following incident management procedures, the event was classified as a Major Incident and escalated to Messaging, Infrastructure, and Network teams for coordinated investigation and response.

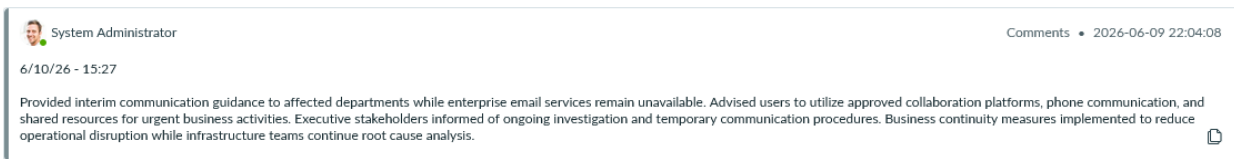
 System Administrator Comments • 2026-06-09 21:54:04

6/10/26 - 15:24 • Reviewed authentication and messaging service alerts. Confirmed enterprise-wide impact affecting multiple business units. Initial investigation indicates issue is related to centralized email infrastructure rather than individual user devices. Collected incident data and provided updates to Messaging, Infrastructure, and Network teams. Continuing to monitor service status and communicate updates to affected users while root cause investigation remains in progress.



Screenshot 3: Enterprise Impact Analysis and Cross-Team Coordination

Tier 1 investigation confirmed the outage was affecting multiple departments across the organization and was not isolated to individual users, workstations, or local network issues. Analysis of authentication and messaging alerts pointed toward a centralized email infrastructure problem. Incident data was collected and communicated to Messaging, Infrastructure, and Network teams to support root cause analysis. Service status monitoring and stakeholder communications continued while technical teams worked to restore critical email functionality and minimize business disruption.



Screenshot 4: Business Continuity and User Communication Measures

With the root cause investigation still underway, Tier 1 support shifted focus to minimizing operational disruption across the organization. Temporary communication procedures were distributed to affected departments, directing users to approved collaboration platforms, phone communication, and shared resources for critical business activities. Executive stakeholders received status updates, and continuity measures were implemented to maintain productivity, support customer engagement, and reduce the financial and operational impact of the ongoing enterprise email outage while infrastructure teams continued remediation efforts.

 System Administrator

Field changes • 2026-06-09 22:07:55

Incident state

Resolved was In Progress

Resolution code

Resolved by caller

Resolution notes

Closed by Caller

 System Administrator

Comments • 2026-06-09 22:07:54

6/10/26 - 15:38

Messaging, Infrastructure, and Network teams completed investigation and identified the root cause as an authentication service failure impacting enterprise email connectivity.

Corrective actions were implemented, email services were restored, and successful send/receive testing was verified across multiple departments, including Sales, Finance, Human Resources, Operations, and Executive Leadership.

Users confirmed restoration of normal email functionality and credential prompts are no longer occurring.

Business continuity procedures remained in effect during the outage, including alternate communication methods using approved collaboration platforms and phone communication.

Teams have been advised to review contingency communication procedures and evaluate additional redundancy options to improve resilience during future service interruptions.

Service restored. Incident resolved.

Screenshot 5: Enterprise Email Service Restored and Incident Resolved

Following coordinated efforts between Messaging, Infrastructure, and Network teams, the root cause was identified and remediated. Email functionality was successfully restored across all affected departments, and validation testing confirmed normal message flow and authentication services. Business continuity measures helped minimize operational disruption during the outage. The incident was formally resolved after user confirmation, service verification, and communication of post-incident recommendations designed to improve future resilience and reduce business risk.

Professional Summary

This incident demonstrated the difference between individual ticket resolution and enterprise incident management. Rather than treating the outage as a single-user issue, the investigation focused on identifying the scope, validating business impact, coordinating communications, and supporting the teams responsible for restoring service.

Using the SORT methodology, the incident was documented from initial user reports through final resolution. Multiple departments, including Sales, Finance, Human Resources, Operations, and Executive Leadership, were affected. User reports were correlated with monitoring alerts, allowing the issue to be quickly identified as an enterprise-wide outage rather than a workstation or application-specific problem.

Throughout the incident, priority was placed on maintaining business continuity while technical teams investigated the root cause. Temporary communication procedures were provided to affected users, executive stakeholders received status updates, and alternative collaboration methods were recommended to reduce operational disruption. These actions helped protect customer relationships, maintain productivity, and reduce potential financial impact while restoration efforts were underway.

The root cause was ultimately identified as an authentication-related failure within the email infrastructure. Messaging, Infrastructure, and Network teams implemented corrective actions, verified service restoration, and confirmed successful email functionality across affected departments.

From a business perspective, the most important outcome was not simply restoring email. The objective was to preserve operational stability, minimize revenue loss, reduce customer impact, maintain stakeholder confidence, and ensure accurate communication throughout the incident lifecycle.

This scenario highlights the role of a modern Help Desk professional as a problem solver, communicator, investigator, and business partner. Effective technical support extends beyond fixing technology. It requires understanding how technology supports business operations and

taking action to reduce risk, maintain productivity, and support organizational objectives during critical service disruptions.